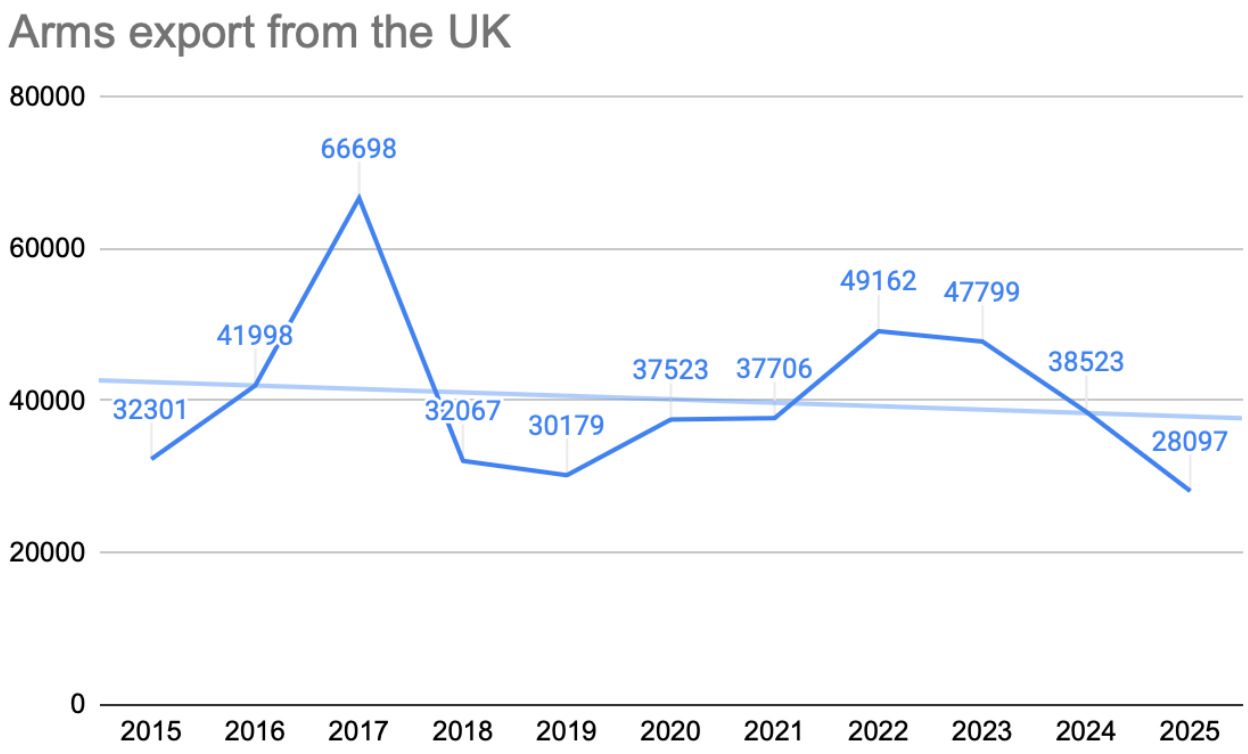
Wk 4 Arms export

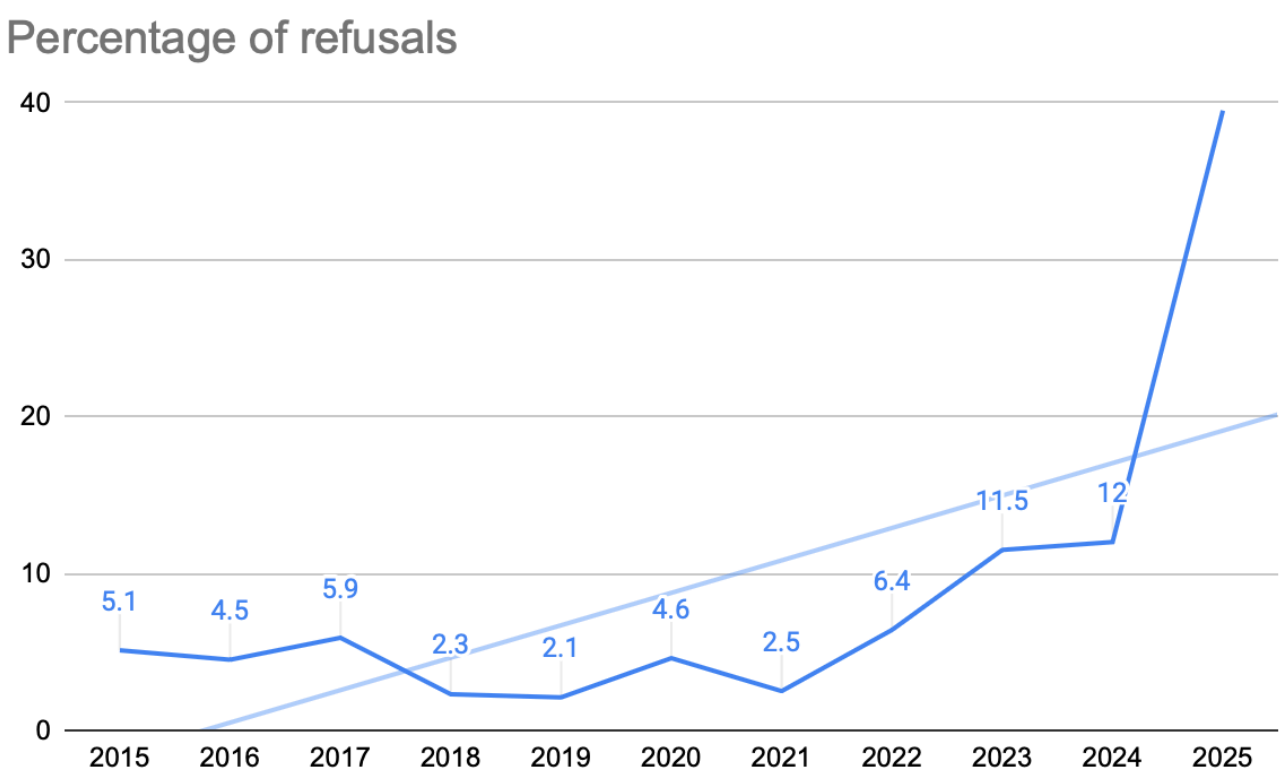
Overall trend

The data shows that overall, arms export from the UK are on a slight downwards trend. But this could be a red herring because the UK government has been increasing the amount of export data in a parallel system that is not public. This means that in 2025, 87% of export license data is unavailable in detail.



Refusals

But the percentage of refusals have shot up drastically.



China is at the top of the list of countries with the highest number of refusals:

destination	SUM of refused
China	2710
Pakistan	1044
United Arab Emirates	1005
Saudi Arabia	1001
Iran	925
Egypt	917
Malaysia	900
Turkey	899
Russia	892

Among the top ten countries with the highest number of entries, China once again has the highest percent of refusal.

destination	SUM of refused	SUM of revoked	COUNTA of item	PERCENT OF REFUSAL

United States of America	453	48	31998	1.4
India	846	2	24999	3.4
China	2710	20	19947	13.6
France	367	8	19926	1.8
Germany	279	2	17026	1.6
South Korea	169	1	15727	1.1
Italy	295	30	15660	1.9
United Arab Emirates	1005	30	14651	6.9
South Africa	810	38	14485	5.6

The figures for Taiwan, Hong Kong and Macao are listed separately from those of China. Curiously, all but Macao have a significantly lower percentage of refusal compared to China

destination	SUM of refused	SUM of revoked	COUNTA of item	PERCENT OF REFUSAL
China	2710	20	19947	13.6
Taiwan	284	35	7751	3.7
Hong Kong Special Administrative Region	247	10	3751	6.6
Macao	46	0	375	12.3

These are the reasons cited for refusals to China: (Albeit this is data for between 2008 and 2026, while we have used the range of 2015 to 2025 till now). Also, reasons are not included in the dataset for all refusals so this data is just indicative and not conclusive.

description	COUNTA of licence_cohort_id
National security of the UK, of allies, EU Member States and other friendly countries.	427
Preservation of regional stability.	21
Risk of diversion or re-export to undesirable end-users.	581
Risk of use for internal repression.	50

UK’s international obligations and commitments under non-proliferation Treaties and Conventions and export control regimes, particularly with regard to proliferation of weapons of mass destruction or ballistic missiles; UK’s commitments and obligations to observe UN, EU or OSCE arms embargoes; Existence of national embargoes or policy commitments; UK’s obligations under the Ottawa Convention and the 1998 Land Mines Act.	406
Grand Total	1485

Value

When it comes to the value of goods exported, China once again comes out on top, as expected.

destination	SUM of value
China	114575079291
South Korea	81480840326
United States of America	31352333823
India	28290231217
Taiwan	21014960190
Saudi Arabia	12413440777
Vietnam	11335026039
Spain	5853676239
Qatar	4666426453
Philippines	3233747838
France	2714322266
Italy	2673147170
Turkey	2577176522
United Arab Emirates	2501554063
Russia	2335614527
Singapore	2323144891
Norway	2176240422
Ukraine	2047227216
Oman	1793722638

Also, various Middle Eastern countries are ranked disproportionately high on this list. For example, Qatar with a population of 3.37 million is in between Spain (49 million) and Phillipines (112 million).